

## The Later Section on Meditative Concentration, Divided in Stages

Dhyānottarapaṭalakrama · Toh 808 · Derge Kangyur

བསམ་གཏན་གཤིམ་རམི་པར་ཕྱེ།

The Later Section on Meditative Concentration, Divided in Stages (Sanskrit: Dhyānottarapaṭalakrama; Tibetan: Bsam gtan gyi phyi ma rim par phyed ba) is a short work on the practice of meditative concentration within the secret mantra, or tantric, tradition. It opens with homage to the glorious Vajratīkṣṇa and a verse of introduction, then insists that mantra practice must rest on scripture and pith instructions, since the vast ocean of secret mantra cannot be fathomed by examples, logical reasons, or inference alone. As its title suggests, it presents the stages of meditative practice as a continuation or "later section" of a larger body of teaching on concentration. It is Toh 808 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the tantra section of the canon.

In the language of India: Dhyānottarapaṭalakrama. In the language of Tibet:  
The Later Section on Meditative Concentration, Divided in Stages.

Homage to the glorious Vajratīkṣṇa.

Even toward the sphere of the secret mantra tantras, there are those whose minds feel no attraction. Yet I am eager to speak of it; if I did not speak, would I not simply fail to live?

This great ocean of secret mantra cannot be grasped by examples, by valid cognition, by logical reasons, by inference, or by discernment alone. Whoever enters some other path without scripture and without the pith instructions will not gain accomplishment from mantra even in a hundred eons. Is there anyone at all who has experienced accomplishment after wholly abandoning scripture and pith instruction? Let alone saying so, there is none.

Then the great-souled secret mantra, surging with waves of accomplishment, whose depths are beyond conception and hard to fathom, can be realized by the foremost of speakers. If you do not know it so, how could you speak of knowing Brahmā? If you take no delight in speaking rightly, then listen to me, for I shall explain.

The awakening mind and the two kinds of suchness, these three: if one knows them, one is a vessel of accomplishment. If you do not know them well, what

accomplishment will you gain?

Regarding the one who accomplishes through the vidyā mantras: is the accomplisher other than the mantra, or not other? What is the fault in either? If it is other, accomplishment will not occur. But if it is not other, then accomplishment is already there. If it is not other and you are accomplished by that, then go now and fly through the sky and the like. If you cannot, then speaking falsehood, go and converse with the cowherds.

Immortal Great Brahmā, honoring your father, having deliberated fully, spoke these words. And what the Lord of the Fearless said: from the other, I have no accomplishment. If accomplishment from the family is not other, do I have accomplishment? If that is so, what is the fault? And what contradiction is there?

Alas, Brahmā! If your mind is utterly stainless and your discernment clear, as I reflect, you realize each word as it is. For one who is other, you have no accomplishment; what is not other is the cause of accomplishment. If you wish to accomplish from what is not other, you would become simply mad. Lord of beings, how do you claim that accomplishment exists? You who have become a lamp of wisdom, please explain how it benefits.

When I examine it thoroughly, is it other than the vidyā or not other? Since it is neither other nor not other, I attain accomplishment through familiarization. If even that wisdom, the unsurpassed object of knowledge, is attained through familiarization, what need is there to speak of accomplishment existing through these ritual procedures?

The suchness of the deity of recitation and one's own suchness, just as they are, without any other support or basis, I realize to be without equal.

From one word leading on to another, the one called Immortal Great Brahmā, with great fortune, desiring accomplishment, came to listen to the Uṣṇīṣa Tantra. Then that Great Brahmā, as he listened to the Vajra Uṣṇīṣa, had flowers of the earth showered down; it is said he was adorned with meditative concentration.

Then the Tathāgata taught the subtle, all-perfect wisdom, the great means of vidyā and secret mantra, also richly adorned with meditative concentration. Showing all the means of yoga, it dispels suffering and sin, as Vajrapāṇi spoke from his own mouth.

Those who commit the sins of birth and death, who cannot remain anywhere, steadfast, abide in this world and the next. The great maṇḍalas and the rest arise, and desired aims are accomplished. By whatever rites, and in whatever way one abides in the activity of meditative concentration, having paid homage to the Tathāgata, I shall explain all of these without omission.

The one called secret mantra meditative concentration was spoken truly as the supreme secret. Even the great ascetic sage cannot accomplish without these. Yogins of secret mantra, through the blazing recitation of secret mantra, destroy birth and death; this was spoken in the past by the Vajra-holder. Therefore here, of secret mantra...

Those who desire accomplishments through meditative concentration and the fire offering should always practice it continuously. First, in that place of the divine body, having made offerings, the wise yogin, together with his place, should visualize the Sugata in front of him. Afterward, he is freed from all limbs, and he abandons the aspect of dividing what is undivided. Subtle, unmoving, and clear, the activity of the mind abides before him.

Having set himself in this way, he meditates with the consciousness of mantra. Restrained, he abides in samādhi, with breath and effort fully held in check. He inclines toward sound, mind, and the basis. The secret mantra abides in the unchanging basis; with the limbs undiminished, he recites the secret mantra. If he grows weary, let him rest himself. The unchanging is endowed with the letters. From basis to basis it changes, and likewise so. For the sake of one's own mantra, whatever has been imagined, he should contemplate the purity of the mind.

Then, having drawn it back in and summoned it, the mind that has held breath and effort in check joins the secret mantra to the mantra by the knowledge of mantra. Let him begin the mental recitation. By this very means, by this rite, or else even by the practice of the sprout, the one who desires accomplishment through knowledge of mantra should not practice recitation in any other way. Through the whole of the knowledge-mantra, through the very reality of oneself and the rite, and through understanding the supreme reality of recitation, a person will attain accomplishment.

In secluded pleasure groves and on riverbanks, in caves, on mountains, and in forests, the mantra practitioner, keeping the observance and the vows, abides practicing meditative concentration. The secret mantra, the abiding fire, is accomplishment; the abiding sound is remembered as bestowing yoga. The

end of sound itself bestows liberation. These three are reality itself. Things that arise from the undivided are to be restrained within oneself by the wise. The mantra practitioner abides beyond the limbs and should contemplate without clinging.

What is called sound is joined in a garland. The unchanging letters, strung together, like the sound of a bell, unbroken: when one contemplates, clinging in the mind, it becomes peaceful within the fire. The words are pure and complete in their limbs. The self, with breath and effort also stopped, having given up sleep, contemplates in detail. The subtle one dwelling in the heart is a stainless disk of the moon. Within it is a flame of fire, perfectly peaceful, radiant with excellent light. Having placed the unchanging basis there, seated at ease, let him contemplate the sound; or let him place the letters upon the unchanging; let him contemplate sound alone.

The meditative concentration that takes sound as its object, even when practiced by itself alone, will bring the aspirant to attain the glory of all supreme things. It appears dependent, as having become limbs. What is called sound, the mental, the pure words, and the power of the knowledge-mantra: the Victor knows the abandoning of limbs. Then the drawing back in, austerity, meditative concentration, the exertion of breath, the actions of rite, and the diverse consciousnesses: the mantra practitioner for now is dependent.

Endowed with great austerity, generating the Dharma, possessing the supreme observance, one who is dependent is freed from the object. Strive to make the limbs appear. Having undertaken the observance, withdrawing from the doubtful and disparaged world, with meditative concentration alone fully restrained, he practices with mind peaceful and steady. Even in matters of semen, excrement, and urine, and even in the movements of the wanderer, let him take up cleanliness in seclusion, in the form of what is doubtful. At scales, wells, and pits, in villages and forests, he gives up by body, speech, and mind: he should practice nothing that harms any sentient being.

For meditative concentration, recitation, the accomplishment of secret mantra, fire offerings, all empowerments, and the activities of the realm, whatever observance has been taught, their places and their measures, and first, with the self alone...

This has been taught as the supreme secret by the god, the great and mighty Vajra-holder. What it means to be drawn near, to be facing directly toward it, and to be one who grants secret mantra, and whatever it is to be turned

toward something other: all of this I explain to you, Brahmā.

All the many wrathful knowledge-mantras, together with secret mantras and the rest, directed toward the body of the Victor, abide constantly for the sake of satiety in meditative concentration.

In the three times, this subtle matter should always be known by the Brahmā who is devoted to accomplishing secret mantra, according to the rite of the ten limbs.

Lack of faith, and torpor; hunger and thirst, and being overpowered by them; likewise restlessness, and distress of mind; doubt about the rite, and gluttony; no delight in recitation or meditative concentration; the breaking of vows; devotion to idle talk; engaging in what should not be done; being led astray by false guides; and even seeing evil dreams. Harming sentient beings, and disparaging the gods: when the practitioner commits these in the practice of the rite, harm will constantly arise. Secret mantra then turns toward something other.

When one abides in peace and has become of the very nature of sound, then the mantra practitioner has drawn near to secret mantra and is facing directly toward it. If gods, asuras, and sentient beings, and those who have entered into sovereign wisdom, see him, peace arises in them. This is what it is to have become manifest.

Kings and the wealthy, men and women of virtue, come under his sway and face him directly. Girls stand by, and bow with their heads. Knowledge arises in him, and even what he has never heard he comes to know. In an instant, from his body, flames blaze forth here and there like fire. Songs and the sweet sounds of cymbals, and even the speech of the gods, such a mantra practitioner, before whom the deity stands manifest, will always obtain.

The practitioner before whom the deity of secret mantra stands manifest is greatly powerful. The wise one, accomplishing austerity, should always be devoted to it wholeheartedly. If he attains the state of being turned directly toward it, it is the state of one who moves through the sky. Though he remain forever among many sovereigns, he who is not intoxicated by them knows mantra.

Even the whole fruit of secret mantra, adorned with the sovereignty of wisdom, when he is intoxicated by it, goes to the supreme state. Made clear by the knowledge of one's own power, it is the supreme secret of the

Vajra-bearer. That which is faultless, Brahmā, by which one attains happiness, is completely perfect, like the Victor.

The one who is joyful and endowed with strength should, through recitation, meditative concentration, and austerity, burn away all misdeeds by the fire that is the nature of secret mantra. If one ever comes to be unconcerned with dwelling, food, cold, rain, wind, and heat, then the fruit of the action is certain.

Whoever strives, unconfused, at sound or likewise at form, should know that it has drawn near. The austere one has abandoned harm. One who by the mere sight of him makes all sentient beings loving, that one draws near to accomplishment. All obstructors are completely abandoned.

Happiness and the end of suffering, desire, anger, fear, sickness, death, and injury: the cause of these resides in mantra practitioners. When ever it has drawn near, then time, body, deed, and action, and the fruits of dharma and non-dharma, no longer depend on mantra.

One who has drawn near to a knowledge-mantra, the desired accomplishment, and likewise the supreme: even if he has committed a thousand faults, there is no doubt that they will be forgiven. Accomplishments born of knowledge-mantras and of substances, and likewise of medicines, for an embodied being who has drawn near and whose mantra is accomplished, are always under his control.

The chapter on the stages of the latter part of meditative concentration is complete. In all it is said to contain fifty-three ślokas.

## Translator's Notes

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, and I have rendered it so. The text is a verse-rich, allusive work, and several lines are syntactically compressed and hard to resolve: especially the Brahmā dialogue on whether the accomplisher is "other" or "not other" than the vidyā mantra, where speakers shift without markers. I have kept the ambiguity rather than resolve it by guesswork. "Two kinds of suchness" for the awakening mind and suchness lines follows a reading of "three" in the verse as awakening mind plus the suchness of deity and self (supported by a later verse); this is a reasoned interpretation, not certain. "Lord of the Fearless" renders the epithet for Brahmā as understood here and is somewhat uncertain. Vajratīkṣṇa is rendered as the Sanskrit for the Tibetan Vajra Rnon-po (Sharp Vajra).
- This passage is exceptionally obscure, evidently a very compressed and corrupt translation of a mantra-meditation tantra (likely related to the Susiddhikara or a similar kriyā text). Several lines remain syntactically uncertain, notably "sprout" (shu bur, possibly a ritual term), the "limbs" (yan lag) language, and the passage on semen, excrement, and urine, which I have rendered literally. The passage ends mid-sentence, as in the source.
- The verse is dense and syntactically loose in this translation tradition. I have rendered

ཕྱག་ཕྱོད་ཕྱོད་པ་ (drawing near, Skt. upasampanna or sāmīpya) and ཕྱག་ཕྱོད་ཕྱོད་པ་ (facing directly toward, abhimukha) as two distinct stages. The line about being intoxicated or not intoxicated by sovereign power (ཕྱོད་པ་) is obscure, and I have kept the ambiguity rather than resolving it. The reference to "the ten limbs" is retained without expansion, since the passage does not enumerate them.

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.